

Kensington UCC
Ascension Sunday
Acts 1 2024

Calling it "kingdom" only works because God is a just ruler, not like earthly kings. Beyond all that. Psalm 47. Or when Paul said "Lord" (jesus not ceasar) John C Holbert "Sacred imagination" like the Christmas truce in WWI

Can you think of times you've been in this phase? Or are you intrigued by it now?

Don't want to get stuck in this dreaming wanting wishing

Actually some level of acceptance needed to just be where you are – "why do you look towards heaven"

Contemplating what is not of the kin-dom, what is out of sync with God's vision

Though there are no neat black & whites here.

But don't want to get stuck here either

And finally taking time to be where you are on the journey, do what you can do in front of you, bc the kin-dom is also here now right with you

settle & reflect, or just be in joy

Learning is justice work

Because we can get so tired & feeling overburdened – too much too much too much, one thing on top of another . we need retreat, to get away, to reset, to interact with others unlike us, or involved in so many different issues,

Not fighting what's ours to do. Just being present to it. "it's not yours to know the time."

Taking action actually prevents empathy fatigue. It's not compassion fatigue. We have endless compassion, as God does

Taking the action in the service of liberation is liberating. When we cannot be silent anymore. We must speak.

And yet Jesus says it is coming. It is just not ours to know the timing. And it is ours to co-create. "Why do you stand..."

When each step in compassion & justice, for others as well as ourselves for our salvation is all tied up, each step is amazing, life-giving, abundant, reshaping, reorienting, we don't want anything else

This is the teaching that fills with joy! Purpose.

The spiritual practice of wondering, mystery, pondering (Lenore asked me which verb...)

That's also an insistence in abundance, that there is time to reflect and grow, that we can invest in community time teaching/talking with others, wondering – that's in our formation

Resurrection to teachings to "he was just here with us"

We are betwixt & both, holding paradox, both/and at the same time

Time – how can it be here & not yet

We may struggle with this, feeling mad at God, or resentful that the issues of our time are in front of us

But God invites & needs us to engage "Why do you stand..."

Eschatology - part of theology concerned with death, judgment, and the final destiny of the soul and of humankind. concerns expectations of the end of the present age, human history, or the world itself.

I think periods of time contemplating & defining our eschatology are natural & important, a season and an inspiration, to imagine & dream the kin-dom come in fullness, God's dream for abundance for all creation, flourishing in full knowledge of our interconnection & joy

Wondering, and it may feel far off. But it will be close. Some may think this earth will pass away, I think "on earth as it is in heaven" indicates it will be like heaven on earth. We will keep our earthly identities and maybe also our bodies because God calls them good, and diversity is beautiful. Yet this diversity will be all about interconnection.

"Repent, for the **kingdom** of heaven has come near."

"Blessed are the poor, for theirs is the **kingdom** of heaven.

Whoever becomes humble like this child is the greatest in the **kingdom** of heaven.

⁴⁵ "Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a merchant in search of fine pearls; ⁴⁶ on finding one pearl of great value, he went and sold all that he had and bought it.

But he said to them, "I must proclaim the good news of the **kingdom** of God to the other cities also, for I was sent for this purpose."

Seek first the kingdom of God, and all you need will be given unto you

These are just some of the teachings. And in our scripture this am

After his suffering^{let} he presented himself alive to them by many convincing proofs, appearing to them during forty days and speaking about the kingdom of God

Why do you stand looking up toward heaven?

this was central! And experiential. And in stories of our lives. (go to bible gateway & look up "kingdom")

And at the heart of so many of Jesus's teachings is paradox – that to live life fully one must lose it, must give up protective concern of self to think of the collective bc it is in the collective we live abundantly (we are interconnected)

That the kin-dom is both here and not yet, breaking in not yet fully, and yet abundant, abundant & coming (Why do you stand looking up toward heaven?) you can see heaven here, on earth as it is

God is both beyond & here, Immanent & imminent, inherent & impending, within & without

That to help others we must acknowledge our own struggles, fallibility – recognize our common humanity & in doing so find self-compassion for ourselves as well

But what do we do that we're in the middle – we feel unsettled, uncertain, weighed down by all creations struggles, but issues that feel so insurmountable. The fatigue can have us questioning whether peace & justice for all creation is even possible.

1 In the first book, Theophilus, I wrote about all that Jesus began to do and teach **2** until the day when he was taken up to heaven, after giving instructions through the Holy Spirit to the apostles whom he had chosen. **3** After his suffering^[a] he presented himself alive to them by many convincing proofs, appearing to them during forty days and speaking about the kingdom of God. **4** While staying^[a] with them, he ordered them not to leave Jerusalem but to wait there for the promise of the Father. "This," he said, "is what you have heard from me; **5** for John baptized with water, but you will be baptized with^[a] the Holy Spirit not many days from now."

The Ascension of Jesus

6 So when they had come together, they asked him, "Lord, is this the time when you will restore the kingdom to Israel?" **7** He replied, "It is not for you to know the times or periods that the Father has set by his own authority. **8** But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth." **9** When he had said this, as they were watching, he was lifted up, and a cloud took him out of their sight. **10** While he was going and they were gazing up toward heaven, suddenly two men in white robes stood by them. **11** They said, "Men of Galilee, why do you stand looking up toward heaven? This Jesus, who has been taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven."

A practice for me of being real with folks

Beginning of Universal Christ, christ within all

Time contemplating the kin-dom. Justice & mercy. The stories.

When we zoom in, we may forget that Jesus announced the kin-dom : near, scriptural prophecy fulfilled in him, his ministry

Humility. The least of these.

God as king. Humility

The protestors also feel they're protesting against colonialism of all forms, anti-blackness, anti-poverty (NY Times) and I just feel that in my bones. Students protesting, I think children are aware too.

The actions of police and administrations in many cases not acceptable,

Yet the response does not dim the light of their action, and the protests are just spreading.
"the kin-dom of God is like yeast"

The children can inspire us, lead us

life wounds – if we don't tend them & receive compassion for them and give compassion to themselves – can lead to cynicism, resistance, hopelessness, despair

Jewish Talmud – seems in this case to be an amalgamation from many rabbis & teachings, co-created- *Do not be daunted by the enormity of the world's grief. Do justly, now. Love mercy, now. Walk humbly now. You are not obligated to complete the work, but neither are you free to abandon it.*

So when we find ourselves in between, may we honor & ponder the mystery in that

And take one action

On earth as it is in heaven